The Words in a Family Care Decision

Wishes, concerns, tradeoffs and criteria, and what to write down for each.

When a family talks about a care decision, a handful of words get used as if they meant the same thing: a wish and an assumption, a hope and a promise, a worry and a fact. This sheet separates seventeen of them, one plain line each, with what to write down.

Most are the Family Care Roadmap's own working words. Where a line follows a public source, it carries a number. The definitions are for keeping the page straight. They aren't for judging anyone's view, or for deciding.

Your loved one's side of the page

Stated wish

Something your loved one has said they want. Guidance for care teams says to record a person's own words as much as possible. [1]

WRITE DOWN The sentence as they said it, the date, and who heard it.

Assumption

Something the family believes your loved one wants but hasn't heard them say. “She'd never want that” is an assumption until your loved one says it themselves.

WRITE DOWN The belief, marked as a belief, and who will ask them about it.

Daily priorities

The routines and small choices that make a day theirs. One federal guide sorts routines into daily ones, such as how the day starts and ends, weekly or monthly ones, and the rare ones that still matter, such as birthdays and anniversaries. [2]

WRITE DOWN The routines and choices they have said they want to keep.

“What matters”

A phrase care teams use for knowing a person's goals and care preferences and fitting care to them. The goals relate to the values and activities that matter most to that person. [1]

WRITE DOWN What they say when you ask what matters to them, without tidying it up.

Person-centered

A way of giving care that is guided and informed by the person's own goals, preferences and values. [3]

WRITE DOWN The goals and preferences you'd want anyone caring for them to know.

The family's side of the page

Concern

What a relative is worried about. It is that person's worry, and it goes under their name.

WRITE DOWN Each relative's main worry, in their own words.

Hope

The outcome a relative wants to see. It says what they want. It doesn't say what they can do.

WRITE DOWN Each person's hoped-for outcome, one line each.

Promise, or offer of help

Help a relative says they will give. The Family Caregiver Alliance's advice is to ask each person directly and specifically for what they can really give, and the National Institute on Aging says no one can be expected to do everything. [4] [5]

WRITE DOWN What each person can do and how often, and what they've said they can't.

Competing expectations

Two things people are counting on that don't fit together as described. One relative expects another to be there every day; that relative expects to keep working.

WRITE DOWN Both expectations, side by side, without choosing between them.

The shared page

The decision

The one question the family actually has to answer, written as a single plain sentence.

WRITE DOWN The sentence, any date attached, and whether everyone accepts the wording.

Area of agreement

Something every relative involved has said they want or can accept.

WRITE DOWN Each one in a line, checked with the people it speaks for.

Unresolved difference

A point where people still disagree after talking. The Family Caregiver Alliance says not all the issues in caregiving and decision-making can be solved. [6]

WRITE DOWN The difference in neutral words, and who holds each view.

Consensus

Everyone agreeing. It is welcome and it isn't required. Agreement that exists only because people stopped talking isn't consensus.

WRITE DOWN Who has actually said yes, and who has only gone quiet.

Tradeoff

Getting more of one thing that matters by accepting less of another. A federal toolkit on person-centered thinking notes that some things take priority over others at different times in our lives. [2]

WRITE DOWN The two things pulling against each other. Don't settle it on this sheet.

Decision criteria

What a family agrees a choice will be measured against, settled before options are compared. They are worked out later in this step, with the full picture, and not on this sheet.

WRITE DOWN Nothing yet, beyond what your loved one and each relative have said matters.

Question for a professional

Something the decision depends on that nobody in the family can answer. The National Institute on Aging suggests listing questions before an appointment, starting with the most important ones. [7]

WRITE DOWN The question, and who it goes to: a doctor, a nurse, a social worker, a care consultant.

Facilitator

A neutral person from outside the family who helps a meeting along. The Family Caregiver Alliance names social workers, ministers, private case managers, physicians and hospital discharge planners as people who can do this or refer you. [6]

WRITE DOWN Whether the family wants one, and who will ask.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't say whose view should carry, which tradeoff to make, or what your family's criteria should be.

Ready for the next step?

You can tell a stated wish from an assumption and a hope from a promise, and you know what goes on the page. The care interview fills in the rest of the picture: it takes you through your loved one's situation one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults
2. Administration for Community Living (National Center on Advancing Person-Centered Practices and Systems), Office of Healthcare Information and Counseling Person-Centered Thinking Toolkit
3. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Person-Centered Care
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
5. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
7. National Institute on Aging, Taking Someone to a Doctor's Appointment: Tips for Caregivers